Independence in 1947 by the departing imperial forces, whom Bhagat Singh and other revolutionaries such as Ashfaqullah Khan so vehemently opposed and which many on both sides of the border continue to regret to this day—often obscures this fact. Yet, the reality is that even before then, as Aijazuddin makes clear, '[c]enturies of hostility had divided Sikhs and Muslims until what had been a common approach to God – a belief in monotheism – had become blurred by blistering resentment and bloody outbreaks'. In the event, '[t]he fabric of their communal history bore indelible stains of blood, primarily Punjabi blood, spilt or shed to defend divergent and ultimately opposing causes'.[6] It is precisely because of a history of such needless blood-letting, which arose when the peoples of Punjab misguidedly staked out for themselves 'divergent and opposing causes', that Bhagat Singh can help remind them, as Maharajah Ranjit Singh once did, that they have an ineradicable common culture and deep-rooted ties with each other. The legacy of Maharajah Ranjit Singh has been largely lost over time. Only a few men of letters, stalwarts such as Fakir Aijazuddin, have devoted themselves to keeping it alive in Pakistan. Otherwise, it is either forgotten or deliberately suppressed. In Pakistan, this is for reasons both religious and political. In India too, those who remember Ranjit Singh's true legacy of secularism, religious tolerance and communal coexistence are few and far between. He does not figure prominently in school history textbooks. And Indians are barely able to recall how Ranjit Singh kept the marauding eye of the foreign invader in check by commanding the most powerful army in all of Asia.

It is almost entirely unknown that in the day-to-day administration of his kingdom, Ranjit Singh relied on Muslim administrators' impeccable credentials and loyalty. These were the Fakir Brothers (Fakir Azizuddin, Imamuddin and Nuruddin). Yet the contribution that these 'three brothers from a Muslim family . . . had made to enhancing the image of the Sikh Court of Lahore during the rule of Maharajah Ranjit Singh' and 'in the tumultuous period thereafter'[7] is one which is still today so undervalued and largely unrecognized, not least in Lahore itself, that they have failed to become the household names on both sides of the border, which they so